THE THICK RED LINE

CHINA HAS BEEN BEEFING UP ITS BORDER INFRASTRUCTURE FOR YEARS. INDIA IS BOLSTERING ITS CAPABILITIES IN RESPONSE



Brian Hart, Bonny Lin, and Matthew Funaiole elaborated on the PLA's growing capabilities in its Western Theatre Command (WTC), which oversees Tibet and Xinjiang. They highlight that there are over 50 airports and helipads in Tibet and Xinjiang, of which 36 have been constructed and upgraded since 2017, with new ones closer to the Indian border. The under-construction Ngari Burang airport and the Shigatse Tingri airport are positioned 60 km from the Indian border. The authors wrote that earlier, over 500 km separated Chinese airports and Indian strategic facilities. Now, for example, the Bareilly Air Force station is only 200 km from Ngari Burang.

An Indian defence analyst adds that at the Lhasa-Gonggar airport, around 250 km from Tawang, Arunachal Pradesh, hardened aircraft shelters and a runway are under construction, with the added presence of radar and electronic warfare units. The Hotan airfield, too, has an expanded runway and new buildings, along with UAVs and J-20 stealth jets. At Shigatse, 155 km from the Indian border in Sikkim, China deploys its frontline fighter jets, and CH4 and WZ-7 reconnaisance drones patrol the border, says an analyst. After the Yangtse clash,

ROADS AND RAIL WILL SOON CONNECT LAC FLASHPOINTS LIKE AKSAI CHIN, DEPSANG, GALWAN AND PANGONG TSO WITH THE CHINESE HINTERLAND FOR MILITARY ADVANTAGE

north of Tawang district, in December 2022, China deployed its advanced drones closer to the border. "Upgraded airfields in Tibet, where the presence of stealth aircraft and UAVs is detected, indicate Chinese intentions," an observer claims.

Apa Lhamo, a research fellow at the Delhi-based Centre for China Analysis and Strategy, draws attention to China's proposed G695 highway that would link Xinjiang with Tibet.